



THINKING ABOUT YOUR THINKING

Your wonderful, secret, lifetime
collaboration with your own brain.

Dan Sullivan

Cartoons by Hamish MacDonald

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Thinking About Your Thinking

Most people's thinking ability is limited. But there's a dimension of thinking called Thinking About Your Thinking where you step back and observe your own mind. It's a subtle mental shift that creates a massive change in perception and possibilities—a shift that Dan Sullivan discovered early in life, which went on to become the basis for every concept and tool in The Strategic Coach® Program.

Here, you'll discover for yourself how to step out of the specifics of any situation, see it from a whole new perspective, and take action in a positive way.

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Introduction

My Life In One Unique Capability

You've increasingly created many shortcuts and solutions — and you realize all of them come from “Thinking About Your Thinking.”

It started in 1950 when I was six years old, wandering the fields and woods of our family farm in northern Ohio. I was allowed to go pretty much wherever I wanted to go on the property, as long as I was accompanied by the family dog. One day, I suddenly realized that I could think about my thinking.

I remember it, more than 70 years later, as watching my brain jump from one thought to another, and getting new ideas as a result. It was enormously energizing and intriguing because I had come upon a secret world inside my own mind. In the dimension where I could think about my thinking, there was a tremendous sense of safety and connection. Rather than feeling like things were just happening to me, I felt like / was happening to me.

Suddenly watching my brain create.

I realized that I had an ability, a secret place I could go, where my own thinking, inside of me, was as intriguing and stimulating as anything I was discovering outside of myself.

It felt good to be an observer of my own thinking, to pop out and become a spectator, not of what I was doing, but of how I was using my brain. And it was going through this experience that led me to becoming interested in other people's thinking.

It allowed me to send my thinking farther afield than before

and to return to thoughts I'd had in previous days, as though watching a movie I could rewind at will. And ever since I first discovered this ability, it's been something I can use whenever I feel down. I ask myself what I'm thinking about, and it always turns out that it's not things that are happening to me that are getting me down, but how I'm thinking about things.

Enormously energizing discovery.

I was out alone in the fields and woods, but this thinking discovery somehow made me feel enormously connected and energized. I didn't want to ever stop experiencing this amazing new world.

I knew from early on that what I'd tapped into by being able to think about my thinking was an amazing power. I felt like I'd suddenly discovered a whole extra set of rooms hidden behind the ones where I lived. It was like finding a secret dimension.

And I was going to take advantage of having a lot of opportunity to return to that world where I was the observer of my own thinking.

Come-and-go frustration.

The first experience was exhilarating but then disappeared. Weeks later, it came again, exciting as before, and—*poof!*—gone. I had discovered a secret world to which only I could enter, and I loved it there. What's more, I recognized even at that early age what a power it was to be able to go to this place and think about my thinking.

Now, practically as soon as I'd discovered that this place and this ability existed, I was experiencing the profound frustration of not being able to bring on the experience whenever I wanted to. In other words, I knew it was there and that it was amazing, but I could not come and go as I pleased. A dozen more times came and went. Then, out of frustration, I learned the trick of having it come when I wanted.

“What am I thinking about right now?”

It was six months into this fascinating series of experiences that I finally had the breakthrough. I asked myself, “What am I thinking about right now?” and as soon as I answered, I could do magic. Just like that, I was observing myself thinking.

Just by asking this one simple question, I could transport myself so that I could see things differently. I was able to take myself out of an experience, and after a few minutes, whatever I had been feeling would go away. I started to see a separation between what was actually happening and how I was thinking about what was happening. I could watch what my brain was doing and change how I thought about things.

Our thinking nature and emotional nature are not always in sync, and I've found that when I feel bothered by something, it's because my thinking and my emotions aren't integrated. But when I snap into thinking about my thinking, I can make sense of how I'm feeling in a way that I can't when I'm caught up in the experience.

As humans, I believe we develop our intellect to make sense of our emotions—to be able to step back and examine why we're feeling the way we're feeling.

70 years' deepening and expanding.

This metacognitive capability is a permanent one. It's been a part of my life since I first developed it at that young age. And while I don't think I ever ran into anyone else who had this ability before I left home, I did become increasingly interested in engaging with other people who were able to think about their own thinking.

Since 1950, I've lived increasingly more of my life inside of this single extraordinary ability. I've kept getting better at it, mastering it for myself, and now creating hundreds of ways for others to think about their thinking.

It was around the age of 19 or 20 when I embarked on the next stage of having this skill, which was to find other people who could do it, or to teach other people how to do it. And in my entrepreneurial life, which began when I was 30, I've made a living using this capability of asking people the right questions to prompt them to think about their thinking in a way they never have before so they can experience breakthroughs and take action to achieve their goals.

Not a typical way of thinking.

This isn't something that's typically taught. Instead, most education involves thinking about other people's thinking. But when you're thinking about your own thinking, you're in a space where there's no competition, no concerns about status or about time slipping by, and no feeling of scarcity. It's a radically different world free from jealousy, envy, resentment, and anxiety.

And as I got older, I saw that this ability could lead to transformation.

Chapter 1

Three Kinds (And A Fourth)

You realize that most people think about Things, People, and Thoughts, but only a few can Think About Their Thinking. You're one of them.

I developed my unique thinking ability gradually over many years, from age six until age 30. Over those years, I never detected this skill in anyone I met, whether family members, other students, my teachers, or any adults I encountered along the way.

What I did notice was that everyone else thought about many other things in their lives, three in particular. They thought about Things, they thought about People, and they thought about Thoughts (not their own, but other people's). They had these three kinds of thinking, but not the fourth—Thinking About Their Thinking.

At that time, I always felt apart from other people because I didn't spot this capability in anyone else, and my main experience of those years was of being alone. But it was never a negative experience for me.

Gradual until age 30.

I stayed with the simple "What am I thinking about right now?" approach to activate my Thinking About My Thinking every week or so for a long time, from age six until age 30. Growing up was a very busy time, with much learning in many different areas. But I knew very young that my secret thinking ability was unusual. And it was mine.

When I was in this state, I was freed up from the emotions, anxiety, and Things, People, and Thoughts that captured other people my age. This ability allowed me to shield

myself from these things. It wasn't an offensive capability—it was a *defensive* capability.

It wasn't until I was 30 that I got a handle on the fact that I could use it to actively create an external world. I was focused on my ability to Think About My Thinking, which allowed me to engage with an infinitely expandable future.

Cracking the adult code.

I was born into a big family, number five of seven with no other children as playmates until first grade. Counting my parents, there were lots of adults. When I was four, I learned to ask questions of older people in such a way that they would tell me their life experiences. I found that I could crack the adult code by asking them about their pasts.

When adults answered my questions and told me about their pasts, they weren't experiencing their past the way it happened—they were changing the meaning of the experience and making connections. What I did by asking them questions was create a situation in which they learned from their own experience and gained insight from their past.

And I, in turn, learned from them. While I found reading books interesting, when I was interacting with adults, I was learning first-hand from historians, which I found far more interesting.

No one else did it.

I noticed that adults had lots of experiences and lessons, but when I started school, I found that none of my classmates had either. So I was far more interested in asking questions of adults.

Another big discovery I had was realizing that none of the adults ever recounted Thinking About Their Thinking as one of their experiences. I was on my own when it came to this. It's what differentiated me from my entire family, and then what differentiated me at school.

The adults I spoke to appreciated the experience because Thinking About Their Thinking wasn't something they did for themselves, and it wasn't something they did with anyone else. The result was that I got enormous favors from adults, and they opened a lot of doors for me.

Three kinds of thinking, period.

I was into my teenage years when I realized that for everyone else I talked to, there were three kinds of thinking: They thought about the Things in their life. They thought about the People in their life. And they thought about the Thoughts in their life. And these three filled all of their time.

Human thinking is usually defined by these three lifetime engagements we have with the reality outside of ourselves. The first is the *Things* we're surrounded by, and this varies according to where you're living and what's nearby, and includes places and situations.

Thinking about *People* includes the individuals in your life of all ages, backgrounds, and personalities, as well as those throughout history who have influenced you through their books, through stories you've heard about them, and so on. This is also overlaid with emotion because we respond emotionally to every person we meet.

Thoughts refers to the thoughts of other people—our parents, siblings, teachers, neighbors, politicians, writers—that we hear throughout our lives. From the beginning of our lives, we hear other people’s ideas. It takes quite a jump in intelligence to understand that there’s an internal world where you can think about your *own* thinking, and there are some people who just never develop it.

Number four was the future.

After I graduated from high school, it became clear that Thinking About My Thinking was a fourth way to use my brain, and it was something no one else seemed to be doing. It was also clear that it was superior to thinking about Things, People, and Thoughts and that it was the key to my future.

By the end of high school, I’d been doing this for 12 years, and I understood more and more that it led to independence and freedom. I’d gotten so much out of Thinking About My Thinking, and I’d seen others get so much out of my prompts to help them think about their own thinking, that all other types of learning seemed to pale in comparison.

Our own experiences seemed to be incredibly more useful and powerful than any lessons learned from school, from reading, or from anywhere else. So I thought, there needs to be an educational system completely created by the students out of their own experience where the purpose of the teacher is to get them to Think About Their Thinking. And that’s how Strategic Coach was born.

Chapter 2

Things, People, And Thoughts

You are clear that thinking only about Things, People, and Thoughts forces you into continual comparison and competition.

I was a slow learner in thinking about what most other people thought about. I knew that Things, People, and Thoughts were the only kinds of thinking they did. I also knew there was a fourth kind of thinking and didn't know right away how all four ways of thinking fit together. What I did know, however, was that operating within just three ways of thinking forced me to compare myself with others and to compete with them. When I was inside of Thinking About Your Thinking, this wasn't true.

From the time we're born, we're surrounded by physical things, and because we experience things emotionally before we figure them out intellectually, we can get very attached to them. For many people, their attachments to objects leads to the ways they define and think about other people.

They compare what they have to what other people have. It's a never-ending cycle of comparison and competition, and it's not until you get into Thinking About Your Thinking that you're free from all of this.

Connected, engaged, committed.

In the "three thinking world" of Things, People, and Thoughts, every individual lives uniquely (and unequally) in relation to everything and everyone else. Most people are connected to, engaged with, and committed to what and who surrounds them in ways that preoccupy them for a whole lifetime.

They feel so connected to their first experiences, and they engage more and more with them, and then they become really committed to those Things, People, and Thoughts for the rest of their life. But there's no flexibility. They keep reinforcing a set of early concerns.

Other people are the number one influence on them, and they're constantly calculating their status within the human framework. Things are also a really important part of their status with other People. So are the Thoughts they think and talk about. The full-time obsession with Things, People, and Thoughts is a game, but it's not a game you can win.

Endlessly more things.

You realize that there are trillions of things surrounding you that engage all of your senses and trigger all of your reactions. The moment-by-moment experience of this environment of things, both natural and created, can capture many people's entire available attention for a lifetime. This is all they can think about.

There's always something you can be reading on social media, watching on television, or buying online. And there are many people who, over the course of their regular lives, never sit alone and Think About Their Thinking.

And people who spend their entire lifetimes accumulating things never find that they have enough. They buy bigger and bigger places to live so that they can keep all of their things and still buy more, renting out storage spaces to accommodate all of them. There are never enough things to make them happy.

Always different people.

You've encountered hundreds, thousands, perhaps millions of different people in one way or another who have impacted you in many different ways, both positively and negatively. You could spend all your available time thinking about them and comparing yourself to them, wondering what they think and competing with them.

I went to the “Great Books” college, St. John's, because I wanted to know where all the thoughts in the world came from. During the four years I was there, it was nothing but reading and discussing the thoughts of great Western philosophers. There was a process of connecting with, becoming engaged with, and then committing to a particular person's thoughts.

It seemed to me that everybody was getting attached and committed to a particular thinker. They weren't necessarily being influenced to think like the thinker, but they were getting attached to knowing this person's thoughts and debating with others about whose thoughts were better. To me, it seemed like I was right back into self-comparison. And what I took away from the experience was that the key is to think about your *own* thinking.

Limitlessly distracting thoughts.

Each day, your time is captured by your own thoughts, some old and recurring, some emerging and new. The vast majority are wave after wave of other people's thoughts—too many to know their source. At any given time, dozens of these thoughts are competing for your complete attention.

For most people, thinking about Things, thinking about

People, and thinking about other people's Thoughts is enough. They spend their lives distracted by attachments they made in childhood, thoughts they had in the past, and messages communicated by an enormous variety of other people.

You'll never run out of possible distractions. But unlike most people, you know you can always take the time to engage with your own thoughts. You can escape the endless distractions in the world by Thinking About Your Thinking. Just asking yourself the question, "What am I thinking about right now?" focuses your brain.

Fitting all four together.

You immediately recognize that, for most people, these three kinds of thinking are their whole life. But what about the fourth kind, Thinking About Your Thinking? Where is there any time or attention in people's lives for that? We'll now go deeper to see where number four fits in.

You are about to enter the realm of Thinking About Your Thinking. Unlike with the first three thinking types, here there is no comparing yourself to others, and there's no living your life in competition with others. You're aware that you're unique, so comparison and competition are not what you're looking for and aren't useful to you.

You can fully enjoy the Things, People, and Thoughts in your life and be improving them—not for status purposes, but because they match your increasing capability of thinking. I want Things, People, and Thoughts in my life that resonate with my current highest level of thinking.

Chapter 3

Thinking About Your Thinking

You increasingly learn how to improve your behavior and results by understanding and transforming your thinking in any situation you choose.

You already know that “normal” thinking isn’t where your success comes from. Therefore, you’re open to trying new approaches to thinking better. This better way can be achieved by simply asking yourself, “What am I thinking about right now?”

Before asking yourself the question, you were enmeshed in emotional reactions to your circumstances, reacting to some Thing, some Person, or some Thought—and often some combination of these three. You were feeling confined and restricted. But after asking yourself the question, you’re immediately in a different thinking dimension.

One example of the way I coach entrepreneurs to Think About Their Thinking is through my concept of The Gap And The Gain. People will have reached a certain level of success or accomplishment, but if they’re looking ahead and comparing themselves against their ideal, which is a moving target, they’re always going to feel like they’re failing.

I coach them to turn around and look back at where they came from, at all of the progress they’ve already made. Suddenly, they switch to a positive mindset and leave behind the trap of self-comparison simply by Thinking About Their Thinking and choosing to look at the same situation in a different way. Nothing’s changed except their thinking.

Asking the question.

You develop this question, “What am I thinking about

right now?” as a permanent habit that you use every time you feel confined or restricted by any situation you’re in. This becomes automatic when you find yourself reacting emotionally to some combination of Things, People, and Thoughts. Whenever you’re feeling trapped, you know what to do to get out and immediately change your outlook.

As soon as I ask myself, “What am I thinking about right now?” I’m immediately back in the present, and I’m letting the experience happen. This is key because when you’re actually in the present, you’re not reactive to it—you’re just experiencing it. And this allows you to see similarities between your present situation and ones you’ve been in at points in the past, so you can determine the right solutions for your present situation. Now, there’s no reason to feel apprehensive about new experiences. You have a way to always transform them.

Your brain automatically switches.

You notice (try it right now) that your brain can’t ignore this question. You immediately switch from whatever was controlling your attention to a different thinking space. Instead of thinking inside of a box, you are now outside of the box.

Our brains can ignore statements, but they can’t ignore questions. So when you ask yourself a question, you immediately change. What’s going on in your brain? Before, you were feeling an emotional reaction, but as soon as you ask this question, your brain is forced to focus on what you’re doing right now and what’s actually going on in the present.

That immediately removes you from the emotions of the situation. Your feelings change, and just like that, you’re back in charge of the situation. Yes, you’re in an experience, but

the experience isn't happening to you. You're just noticing what's going on in the experience. And you can think about the experience, and it immediately moves you to another dimension where you can evaluate it more objectively.

How you're thinking.

You'll notice that just a few seconds ago, you were thinking about *what*. But now, outside the box, you're thinking about *how*. You're now thinking about how you were thinking about what's inside the box. You're now Thinking About Your Thinking. It's that simple (but maybe not yet easy).

For me, it took a long time because I couldn't automatically get back to the level of thinking that I experienced. But I made it a habit. I recognized that this was a new skill and I could use it any time I chose. Every time I asked myself, "What am I thinking about right now?" it would return me to that dimension.

I still encounter situations where I forget. I get angry at a situation, or I feel aggrieved at something. But then, the moment I ask the question, I'm out of that situation.

Instantly freed-up dimension.

You'll also notice that you're no longer reacting emotionally. Whatever was occupying your attention has lost its hold on you. You feel freed up, and whatever the Things, People, or Thoughts were, you're now free to examine how you're thinking about them.

You enter a separate dimension that you create for yourself where you can access all of the good thinking you've done over your entire life, and benefit from it by applying the appropriate thinking to your present situation.

It's so important to get out of a reactive state. When we're emotional, we can't think properly, and our ability to act is suspended. Our vision gets very narrow, and we become fixated on what's going on. We're forming judgments, but we're not thinking things through; we're just responding.

When you're Thinking About Your Thinking, you see the experience in a different way and are able to relate it to other experiences. You're not relating to it emotionally. You can stand back and say, "Where have I seen this before?"

Getting above it all.

Thinking About Your Thinking is the best lifetime ability to have. And now that you know the question that enables you to do it, you can keep getting better every day for the rest of your life. Whatever your experiences of Things, People, and Thoughts are from now on, you can choose to get above them.

When you Think About Your Thinking, all of your strengths are available to you. You can access all of your abilities, all of your confidence, and all of your commitments. We are only useful to people when we're doing our best thinking, and this question is how we allow ourselves to think at our best.

Knowing how the question works, how best to use it, and how to make using it a habit means that you'll never again feel stuck or trapped in any situation. No matter what happens, you can experience situations instead of having experiences happen to you.

Chapter 4

Instantly Jump From “Normal”

You love the experience of immediately switching out of your normal thinking restrictions related to Things, People, and Thoughts.

As soon as you ask yourself the question, “What am I thinking about right now?” in any situation, you gain a totally new perspective. Just a few seconds prior, you were feeling confined in the circumstances. But suddenly, you feel freed up and are looking at things differently. Before the switch, you were reacting to the experience, but now you’re above it. You’re responding rather than reacting.

This is a marvelous feeling because you also realize that you can respond in this way to any other situation, at any time and in any place. You have a powerful new skill you can use anytime you choose, and it’s yours from now on.

“Normal” thinking is what’s expected. There’s a consensus going on. Everyone is feeling around the edges, and no one’s going to the heart of the matter. By asking yourself the question, you’re thinking differently, and you’re going to the heart of the matter.

You escape from the normal with your unique, specific perspective. You don’t deprive yourself of any experiences, but you don’t expect circumstances to explain themselves. You know you’re the one who has to think about them and make sense of them.

Totally new perspective.

You’re amazed at the magic change your thinking undergoes just from asking yourself a simple question. One

moment, you're inside of the "normal" experience of Things, People, and Thoughts. A moment later, answering the question switches everything. You're seeing things from a totally different perspective.

When you're inside of the situation, you can't access all of your experiences. You feel trapped, cut off from everything you've learned from your life so far. But when you're *above* the situation, Thinking About Your Thinking, you have complete access to your past experience.

You're able to compare your current situation to previous situations, seeing in what ways it corresponds, and you can understand the true significance of the situation. The question overrides whatever you're feeling, switching you over to using your thinking ability, and you suddenly have perspective.

Anytime, any place.

You discover that you can ask the thinking question in any kind of daily situation. It doesn't matter what you're experiencing—you can switch out of it in a few seconds. And asking yourself the question, "What am I thinking about right now?" is just like exercising a muscle. Each time you do it, it gets stronger, making it easier the next time.

There is no limit to how many times per day you can ask yourself the question. You can use it every time you need to use it, and it will work for you every single time.

You have a separate world that is entirely, uniquely yours, and you can access this world immediately whenever you find that you're having trouble with the present circumstances.

And that's true no matter what. You're not escaping from experience, but engaging with it capably and confidently.

Marvelous feeling.

Not only are you seeing things differently, you're also feeling the experience as powerfully transformative. It feels marvelous, delightful, humorous, and playful. That's because you realize at the deepest level that you're not a prisoner of your circumstances. You can change any situation with this question. You're in charge of your life.

Every time you use your capability to Think About Your Thinking, it gives you a feeling of comfort and security. You think about how you were feeling only a few seconds ago, and you love how quickly and easily you've transported yourself into a new way of thinking and transformed the situation that you're in.

You know you can do this in every situation and that nothing the world throws at you can knock you off balance.

Uniquely yours.

You also realize that the world of Things, People, and Thoughts that you were born into was fully formed before you got here. It's been developing for millions of years. None of it was your idea. Therefore, you can think about it any way you choose to make it interesting and useful to you. Ask the question, and how you see it is uniquely yours.

The actual thinking that one person does about this is unique from the way another person would do it. This is because it pulls into play the experiences of your entire life, which are unique to you. This includes your perspectives,

the meaning you've created, your goals, and your resources. It's unique to you, and you can take full ownership of all of it.

Responding, not reacting.

Being responsible for your life starts as soon as you think about the world around you in an independent manner. This is the opposite of reacting to whatever happens to you.

Reacting isn't thinking at all. It's just a feeling. But Thinking About Your Thinking switches you into the realm of fully creative and satisfying responsibility for your life.

There is a greater possibility to go in this direction for people who are entrepreneurial than for people who are fixed in a particular job or a particular set of circumstances where it's not conceivable to them that they could get out.

As an entrepreneur, you have enough independence from an economic standpoint that you can go out on your own. Once you've already taken major responsibility for your life economically, it's not an enormous challenge for you to start Thinking About Your Thinking. When you're free from fear and from feeling trapped, your brain can do almost anything.

It's already a fact that you don't get paid for conformity; you get paid for non-conformity. You're an independent thinker, and the three regular ways of thinking are not enough for you. You Think About Your Thinking because it's transformative.

Chapter 5

Energizingly Fresh And Exciting

You've increasingly noticed that Thinking About Your Thinking always provides you with a new perspective that energizes you.

It's always there, anytime you're motivated to ask the question, "What am I thinking about right now?" You're feeling stuck, frustrated, or trapped in a situation where "normal" thinking is in control. You feel energy draining away by the minute. Nothing new or stimulating is being discussed. So, it's the perfect time to ask yourself the question.

Within seconds, all of your energy is back. You're immediately seeing your situation from a new perspective, which makes you proud because you've escaped. Old and boring becomes fresh and exciting. Nobody else is noticing anything different but, seemingly by magic, you've changed your understanding of what's going on in entirely new ways.

Your brain can't ignore a question, even if you're the one asking it. And when you ask yourself what you're thinking about right now, your brain immediately starts answering. And suddenly, you're removed from ordinary thought, and you're examining the way you're thinking. It's a secret power. And it's exhilarating when you use it.

For a lot of people, this is hard because they're overwhelmed by their emotions. But when you ask the question, you're instantly freed from the burden of your emotions, and you allow yourself to step back and examine your thoughts.

Always accessible.

You realize that Thinking About Your Thinking is an independent realm. It's an inner, always accessible skill that makes

you increasingly autonomous regardless of time or place or how other people are thinking. Increasingly, your insights, standards, distinctions, and motivations become uniquely yours.

Being autonomous means that the internal laws you create for yourself are more important than external laws, rules, boundaries, and borders.

There are rules that are imposed on you from the outside, but the ones you develop for yourself are not determined by anything that's coming from outside of you. You have an independent realm. As an entrepreneur, you need this to go along with your independent way of thinking and behaving.

No trap, no frustration.

You notice in a growing world of electronic communication, many individuals' entire waking moments are increasingly overwhelmed by fiercely fought competition over Things, People, and Thoughts. So many feel stuck, frustrated, and trapped.

For many people, their overwhelming thoughts about Things, People, and Thoughts are tied up with goals and concerns about status. And these people are worried that they're not living up to what's expected of them, or they don't feel like they're the person they're supposed to be.

Without having and using the capability of Thinking About Their Thinking to change their mindset and perspective, they'll always feel like they're falling short, and they won't be able to find a way to break out of their current, negative state.

But when you can elevate your own thinking, you'll naturally want to help others do it for themselves so that more and more people can leave this trap behind. One of our motivations for independence is that we can then be useful to others.

Immediately new perspective.

When you ask yourself the question, the change is like switching on a light. The competition is gone. The sense of overwhelm disappears. No more feeling trapped. Your thinking is instantly liberated, simplified, and focused. You feel consciously calm, observing everything with a new sense of energizing appreciation.

There is a thrill to immediately seeing things differently. No matter what seemed to be keeping you stuck and trapped just a moment ago, you now have a new perspective, and you can use all of your capabilities and skills.

You no longer feel trapped. All of a sudden, you have a greater understanding of your situation, and you can immediately start seeing similarities with past situations and figure out how to move forward.

Proud of your “trick.”

Every time you pull off this magical thinking trick, you feel increasingly proud of yourself. You feel more capable and confident about your past, present, and future. You forgive yourself for past troubles. You free yourself from future fears. And more so every day, you expand your enjoyment of the present.

We usually think of forgiveness as coming from other people, but the most important thing you have to do is forgive yourself for how you handled situations in the past that you didn't understand. In every situation, you tried, but you didn't have the capability.

Even in the present, you can only do the best with what you have. You maximize what's available to you. It's as true for the past as it is right now, so you have to respect and honor the person you were.

From boring to fascinating.

You observe so many individuals with abundant material lives increasingly suffering from scarcity of meaning. They have plenty of everything—but no purpose for any of it. That's where thinking that's limited to Things, People, and Thoughts gets you: bored and boring! Thinking About Your Thinking makes everything fascinating.

Scarcity of meaning is the ultimate scarcity. The thought that none of this means anything can be very powerful, and it can come from two false understandings. One is that meaning is going to be given to us, and the other is that there is meaning out there that you can discover. Meaning is never discovered—it's created. If you say, "I never saw that connection between those two things before," it's because you hadn't *created* that connection yet.

A lot of people find it unbearable to think that they're responsible for creating all of the meaning in their lives. But you can only be happy if you realize you're responsible for creating your own meaning.

Chapter 6

Surprising New Connections

You're amazed that departing from normal thinking in any situation lets you see creative connections that provide entirely new meaning.

Each time you ask yourself the question, you immediately start Thinking About Your Thinking in new and surprising ways. Every time you begin thinking outside of the norm of Things, People, and Thoughts, your brain connects your experiences in ways that surprise you.

Experiences you've had many times before suddenly reveal entirely new meaning and exciting possibilities. These sudden bursts of creativity and understanding are available to you anytime you choose to ask yourself, "What am I thinking about right now?" Because it never fails to work, you develop a deep and permanent confidence that you'll always be growing.

The human brain is the greatest mechanism in the universe for problem solving and creating new things. There are many years of development in the human brain that happened before you were born, and there's hardwiring in your brain that you have no control over. But you can use your brain—this incredible, creative, problem-solving mechanism—whenever you like for whatever purpose you like.

And it's not intelligence that determines how you use your brain; it's how you use your brain that determines your intelligence.

Creativity lies outside of "normal."

You become increasingly aware—painfully so—that there's no possibility of creativity when you're thinking about your

experiences within the limitations of Things, People, and Thoughts. Being controlled by these normal factors that completely fill daily life prevents any new ways of thinking.

Normal exists because it's necessary. We can't have everybody Thinking About Their Thinking all the time because there are a lot of things that happen in life where we need to be present and alert in the moment, not examining our thinking.

But you can make the time—as much as you need to—to Think About Your Thinking. And you'll find that the more Thinking About Your Thinking you do, the more rewarding doing so will be. So you'll Think About Your Thinking to the degree that it's useful in your life.

Familiar experiences, new connections.

Your biggest immediate surprise when the crucial question enables you to Think About Your Thinking is that everything that is familiar looks different, everything boring looks intriguing, and everything old looks new and exciting. You immediately begin connecting things in new ways.

As an entrepreneur, all the experience you've had is a resource. Over a short period of time, you can Think About Your Thinking and transform an experience you've had into entirely new meaning you didn't see before.

You have the ability to look back into your past and create new meaning anytime. You'll never be able to transform every single one of your experiences, but whichever one you think about, you can create more meaning out of, and it will become valuable to you.

Eliminating friction by making connections.

In March of 2020, after a week of coaching workshops in Chicago, I was on a plane back to Toronto and thinking about the increasing absences in the workshops due to the emerging pandemic and worrying that we would have to cancel workshops.

Halfway through the flight, I started Thinking About My Thinking and was able to step back and consider the fact that we'd handled previous disasters in the past. I knew that I could look back at how we'd handled those situations, take the lessons from them, and gain confidence from knowing we'd overcome obstacles in the past.

As you think about situations where you've been experiencing difficulty, you start making connections that eliminate the obstacles. You eliminate areas of friction that suddenly increase your freedom in new ways.

Sudden new meaning.

You also understand—in ways that never occurred to you inside of “normal”—that the meaning of things is not *discovered*. You don't discover meaning. You don't find meaning. You always create meaning. And you do this non-stop every time you Think About Your Thinking.

And we can give new meaning to something that we gave a different meaning to in the past. No matter how much time has passed since you had an experience, and no matter how you thought about that experience before, you always have the opportunity to revisit an experience you've had and create new, better, valuable meaning out of it.

There's injury, and there's pain, and there's suffering, and these are all real things, but the meaning you choose to attach to any of these things is not a natural consequence of the experience. The meaning of any experience is decided by you. But you have to take 100 hundred percent responsibility for your experience. There's no halfway about that.

Never fails, always growing.

You start on this journey of Thinking About Your Thinking with a sense of caution and worry: caution that you might do it wrong, and worry that it might work once but never again. But with growing success, you become capable, confident, and ambitious. It never fails, and you always keep growing.

If you're worried about how it will go for you, my suggestion is, do it for the first time and see what you think. It isn't a little bit exciting—it's fully exciting.

And though the ability to Think About Your Thinking comes fully formed, it's a skill that improves the more you use it. Your skill will grow because, as you'll soon realize, you can use it anytime in response to any situation.

And you can always go back. There's no expiration date on experiences. Whenever you notice that you have negative thoughts or feelings coming from an experience you've had in your past, you can use your growing skill to transform that experience from something that seems negative into something positive.

Chapter 7

Rejuvenating Everything

Your growing independence from thinking about Things, People, and Thoughts makes you increasingly creative about all three of them.

In the past, you've had creative moments, but they weren't predictable, and you didn't realize that they were actually a skill you can "switch on" anytime you choose. Now, because you know the question, you look at your entire life—past, present, and future—from a totally liberating perspective.

With your new, growing skill of Thinking About Your Thinking, you can now see all these experiences completely free from your old, trapped ways of thinking about them. Before, all of these experiences were a burden. Now, everything old is creatively new.

Until you learn how to Think About Your Thinking by asking the question, you're trapped by the same Things, People, and Thoughts that have made up your entire life. You have experiences, but you don't have the ability to think about them in a new, productive way.

You get bogged down by negative and frustrating memories. You're not seeing the positive in, or getting the value from, your experiences. But the moment you ask yourself, "What am I thinking about right now?" you transform your experiences, creating new meaning and getting new value out of them.

You didn't know how it happens.

When you were a child, you had many creative experiences that you love to remember. But you didn't know why they

happened, and until now, you didn't understand that you can be creative again anytime you want. Now, your future will be increasingly more creative than your past.

It's important for children to play because that's when they're at their most creative. When you enter the school system, though, you're taught quickly that there's no place there for what you created in play. In school, you're there to learn other people's narratives about experience. It's all about taking in received knowledge and established knowledge. You're told you'll be tested on what you've learned about other people's creativity, but not *how* they created.

At their best, humans are creating new thoughts. And now that you have the question, you again have the power you had as a child to create your own meaning and learn from your own experiences.

Totally liberating perspective.

With this amazing skill of Thinking About Your Thinking, it's not just your future that's going to be more creative. Now, it will be your whole life, including everything you choose to remember about your past. This includes all of those happy, creative experiences, but especially all the experiences that were unhappy and uncreative.

In the present, you create a future that's distinctly different from the way you thought about things before you learned the skill of Thinking About Your Thinking. There's an immediate separation between how you performed in the past and the future you're presently creating—a future that's liberated from how you thought about things in the past. There's a thrill in doing this.

You'll also realize that you're not stuck with any memories that drag you down because you can change the meaning of those experiences that have negatively affected your present and future up until now. You can relieve yourself of all those burdens by creatively transforming them into positives.

Everything old becomes fresh and exciting.

Using your new skill, you can revisit and transform everything—Things, People, and Thoughts—that previously trapped you in repetitively negative experiences. In every area where you were reactive and lacking in creativity, you can rejuvenate your entire past.

French economist Jean-Baptiste Say defined an entrepreneur as someone who takes resources from a lower level of productivity to a higher level of productivity. That can involve anything you think of as a resource. I believe my past is a resource that I can take to a higher level of productivity. I transform it in the present, and it becomes useful in the future.

I want all my experiences to be useful to me. That's why I won't accept someone else's interpretation of my experiences and what they mean, or what they should mean.

You can think of it this way: Every time you go back into your past and transform an experience by deriving new meaning from it, you're bringing your liberated self from the future back into your past, along with all of your present skills, including Thinking About Your Thinking.

All experiences serve you.

You love going back to things that you remember as painful frustrations and failures, where you felt powerless. With each experience, you simply ask, “How am I thinking about this right now?” Where previously you were trapped, almost instantly you feel liberated. You feel a wonderful new energy.

You’ll never have any trouble homing in on the next experience you can transform. Your emotions will identify it for you. And you never need to worry about being aware of all your as-yet-untransformed past experiences.

You’re always on to examining the next one, and as long as that’s happening, you won’t care about the vast number you’re not getting to because every one that you do get to becomes useful for your future.

No blame, only opportunity.

Wherever you may previously have felt oppressed by outside circumstances, you now have an ever-more-powerful key to escape from any kind of negativity. Where before you were resentful, you’re now rejuvenated by the same old experiences. All blame vanishes. Your entire life opens up.

You woke up in prison, but you have a key. You can let yourself out of prison anytime you like, and no one will notice, let alone try to stop you. This is because it’s your prison and no one else’s. You no longer blame your past experiences on anything from outside of you.

Chapter 8

Enabling Others To Transform

Your Thinking About Your Thinking transforms every area of your experience for the better, thereby transforming others' thinking.

You notice you've been improving your thinking with regard to everything in your life. Every day, almost automatically, you're increasingly surrounded by Things that are superior in quality and more enjoyable. You're increasingly meeting and attracting higher quality People. And as your thinking becomes more effective, useful, and productive, you seem automatically to discover great Thoughts of other creative thinkers.

But it's getting even better than all that. Your own growing skill of Thinking About Your Thinking is inspiring others around you to learn from your example. They increasingly take advantage of your insights and lessons.

Nothing but good.

You started off thinking about only three things—Things, People, and Thoughts—and you thought about them as being good or bad. Now that you're also thinking in the fourth way—Thinking About Your Thinking—you can have nothing but good Things, People, and Thoughts in your life because in every case, you're making the choice. You can make your whole world increasingly good.

Because you're looking for anything that resonates with your growing ability to Think About Your Thinking, you want Things that are supportive and useful; you want People who are not only supportive, but with whom you can meaningfully interact; and you want Thoughts that connect you to great thinking throughout the ages.

Great Things, People, and Thoughts.

In an amazing, almost effortless way, the more you ask yourself the question, the more everything around you in your daily life gets better. You realize now that before you learned this new, fourth way of thinking, you were trapped by Things, People, and Thoughts. Now, you're free to enjoy them.

Things, People, and Thoughts that used to bother you don't bother you anymore. Not everything necessarily becomes enjoyable, but it does become interesting, even if it wasn't interesting before.

The difference is that you're no longer trapped by Things, People, and Thoughts. You have the ability to think about them in different and better ways. None of them have any power over you anymore.

Others inspired by your skill.

Something else amazes you because you weren't expecting it. Certain individuals are inspired by your uniquely different way of thinking. They see it, they love it, and they want it for themselves. Your example of freeing yourself up increasingly inspires others to discover how you're doing this.

Not everyone will be inspired in this way. For some people who aren't experiencing growth, someone else's growth can seem like a threat. But when you're in a room with people who are inspired by one another, and they start Thinking About Their Thinking, the electricity level goes up.

You go from individual intelligence to the experience of social intelligence and social learning. You'll notice when

other people start seeing things in a creative way. They're not regurgitating other people's thoughts—they're making new connections and expressing their new thinking. And their growth suddenly accelerates your growth and raises your level of confidence.

Learning from your success.

Isn't it strange that your life keeps getting better—and bigger—simply by Thinking About Your Thinking? You've learned how to do this in increasingly successful ways, every day getting better at it. And now others want to learn how you've achieved this so that they can successfully do it themselves.

This is a skill, and all skills are confidence breakthroughs. When you gain a new skill, suddenly the world gets bigger. You can progress at your own pace because nothing is holding you back from getting better.

Uniquely Thinking About Their Thinking.

So, you're intrigued. Can you teach this skill to other people? At first, this looks like a lot of work. But then, another amazing surprise: All you need to do is teach them to ask themselves the simple question that got you started. The moment they do this the first time, they're automatically—and uniquely—Thinking About Their Thinking.

When you ask someone the question, "What are you thinking about right now?" something big happens right away. The person to whom you asked the question starts creating new things on the spot. You'll witness their relief at suddenly being able to Think About Their Thinking.

Just like you experienced when you first asked yourself the question, they're now freed from what had been trapping them all along. And for you, it doesn't necessarily matter what they're thinking about. You know they've learned this new skill because they're now Thinking About Their Thinking.

Powerfully transforming community.

But there's something about this that does require more work. They need to talk about their new freedom because the backward, downward pull of the old Things, People, and Thoughts is still strong. The new way of thinking is best supported by being part of a powerfully transforming community.

There are many habits that are tied to the old, limited way of doing things. So, it takes some time, and you need a strong force that overcomes the power of the previous strong force. Otherwise, it's very easy to get sucked back into old ways of doing things.

There's support in a like-minded community, and so being part of one is very attractive. On the other side of things, a lot of people find that when they're alone, their thinking gets pulled back. But when you're in a good group of people, you're in the present, and everyone is talking about exciting things in the future.

Conclusion

Exploding Free Thinking Zone

You're now in an expanding Free Zone within a growing community of others who are Thinking About Their Thinking.

From the moment you first asked yourself the question that takes you into the realm of Thinking About Your Thinking, you've also experienced greater, expanding freedom in every area of your life. You realize that it's addictive—you can't get enough of it. That was stage one of acquiring the most extraordinary skill of your entire life.

Now, you're in stage two where you're also increasingly surrounded by others who are uniquely Thinking About Their Thinking. One way that everyone describes this new world that you're all exploring and expanding is as a "Free Zone." Everyone is increasingly liberated, and everyone's growing freedom of thinking multiplies everyone else's.

Competition-free zone.

The Free Zone is a much more creative, innovative, and collaborative community than any you've ever been in. This is because you're not tied to the problem of Things, People and Thoughts. You're an independently thinking and creating person, and you're discussing, innovating, and collaborating with other thinking people. And so, magic happens.

There's no competition in this community. Each individual is thinking uniquely and coming up with unique ideas, and you can't "out-unique" someone's uniqueness. Also, everybody's work in becoming unique helps other people in their journey to be unique.

Expanding in every area.

You notice that the better you get at Thinking About Your Thinking, the more you want to do it. You started in one area of your life, but very quickly, you're doing it in all areas. Every area of Things, People, and Thoughts becomes electrified, illuminated, and transformed with your remarkable new capability.

There's no situation into which you can't bring this growing skill of yours. You're not limited by how you're expected to think about something or by how anyone else—or everyone else—is thinking about something. You can always ask yourself the question and create your own meaning.

Stage one was just the start.

The very first time you asked yourself, "What am I thinking about right now?" you were stunned by your suddenly new perspective. It was like something secret that you kept to yourself. This may have gone on, invisibly to others, for a long time. But when you began to share it, you noticed that your capability started multiplying.

At first, and for a long time, you're by yourself. Eventually, you come across another individual whom you recognize is doing the same thing. And at the same time, they recognize you.

This will never fail, as people who are Thinking About Their Thinking have a particular approach. And so you realize that if you can do this with one other person, you can do this with a hundred other people, or with a thousand other people.

Extraordinary multiplying freedom.

You see that everyone who acquires the Thinking About Your Thinking capability never wants to give it up or lose it. Once you're freed from the prison of thinking about only Things, People, and Thoughts, you're totally motivated to spread your new capability to everyone who also wants to be free. This has an endless multiplying effect.

The economy of the world depends upon competition for status among those three things. That's just part of living within the framework of Things, People, and Thoughts. It's intensely competitive from birth until death. But everyone who's made the choice to Think About Their Thinking has made the choice to move beyond that.

Having freedom from those three things is an extraordinary feeling, and the more people who experience it, the better. When someone gains this incredible ability, it doesn't mean that someone else loses it. It means that there's one more person who has left competition behind and is now free to collaborate with other people who have done the same.

Overpowering motivation to share.

Everyone who learns this new way of thinking from you is immediately grateful. Forever. It becomes an overpowering motivation in their life to show others how to do it. Every other way of contributing to others pales in comparison to this one. It's increasingly intoxicating, it's increasingly exciting, and it's endless.

It's a kind of payoff for all the work you did by yourself to get to the point where you could meet with and share with other people. It's great to be able to do this for yourself. But along

the way, you'll wonder, "Can I find someone else who does what I'm doing?"

The answer is yes, and you and the other person will recognize each other as being people who Think About Their Thinking, and you'll both know that you can cooperate and collaborate with each other at a level that's not possible in the competitive world.

It's magical, and now it's normal.

When you encounter anything extraordinarily different like this, you worry that it's so precious that it needs to be protected and hidden. You act like Thinking About Your Thinking is a fragile new creation. But very quickly, you realize that this capability is incredibly resilient and is able to stand up to anything from the outside. It's always magical, but the magic becomes normal.

After all these years, this way of thinking still seems magical to me. But it's the foundation of the world we've created at Strategic Coach—the company itself, the Program, and the relationships. It's very, very magical. But it also happens to be normal because we don't have any people in our world except people who are in *this* world.

There's a deep respect people develop in the thinking processes of The Strategic Coach Program. And then they start creating tools and processes of their own that take Thinking About Your Thinking in completely different and unique directions out into the world.

The Strategic Coach Program

Entrepreneurs Thinking About Their Thinking

You use your Thinking About Your Thinking capability to innovate entirely new solutions that create the best Things, People, and Thoughts in your available world.

You realize in reading this small book that you're an entrepreneur because you've always been thinking differently than everyone else. You know you've always had different dreams, ambitions, and goals than those around you. And now you know why that's been increasingly more possible as you get older.

All of this was because, without knowing what you were doing, you learned how to Think About Your Thinking. Almost everyone you've known along the way has been more and more confined to their specific worlds of Things, People, and Thoughts. This has puzzled you, frustrated you, and perhaps made you angry. But now, you know why they are the way they are and how, through luck and skill, you've created an entirely different world of expanding freedom in all areas of your life.

You've sensed that there's a different world and that it has something to do with the way you think, but you haven't had a method. All tools in The Strategic Coach Program are meant to get you Thinking About Your Thinking. We have tools for everyday life, tools to be used once a week, tools for once a month, and tools for once a quarter—and every one of them will get you to use your unique experience in a particular area to answer the question.

Taking your thinking advantage further.

You now want to continually make your different way of thinking into a uniquely greater advantage. You've already achieved a great deal of different thinking on your own, and now you're excited that Thinking About Your Thinking in a structured way will take you exponentially further.

The structure provided in this book will take you into the activity. You're asking, "What am I thinking about right now?" but it isn't really about what you're thinking about, but *how* you're thinking. Once you've answered that question, Strategic Coach has hundreds of frameworks asking you to answer a series of questions based entirely on your own experience.

We don't know how you're going to answer, but we know you're going to reorganize your experience, and in doing so, you're going to get smarter.

Strategic Coach thinking tools.

Over the past four decades at Strategic Coach, we've collaborated with more than 20,000 talented, successful, and ambitious entrepreneurs to create, test, and refine hundreds of thinking tools, each of which will enable you to Think About Your Thinking related to every area of your life and business.

You get smarter according to your own experience, not smarter about our rules. We don't need any obedience to our approaches. We just want to prompt you to have a discussion with yourself about yourself.

Continual expansion of the Four Freedoms.

As an entrepreneur in Strategic Coach, you're able to achieve remarkable, continually expanded freedom of time, money, relationship, and purpose in both your personal and business life. Your home life transforms, your health and fitness transform, and your company becomes self-managing and self-multiplying.

Through our structure, you can immediately determine whether a situation is a good way for you to be spending your time. If something isn't in service of expanding your Four Freedoms, you'll become clear on that, and you'll make the right decision for yourself. No longer will you make any choice out of unthinking habit.

Transforming Things, People, and Thoughts.

In your marketplace, you innovate continually new and better ways for other individuals to think about their Things, People, and Thoughts. Before they meet you, they feel trapped and frustrated; afterwards, your unique and transformative ways of thinking enable them to feel confident and energized.

Your approach casts away all thoughts, concerns, and worries about status. This means that Things, People, and Thoughts in your life are going to rise to a much higher standard, and you're going to be able to enjoy them far more, without the old concerns about status or competition.

You've transcended things like status, and you've become completely clear on your motivations.

Three growth levels of thinking.

Entrepreneurs experienced in the use of Strategic Coach thinking tools continually grow upward and outward in their mastery of internal teamwork and external collaboration. They progress through the Signature, 10x Ambition, and Free Zone Frontier levels of the Program, using ever-more-powerful thinking tools.

The Signature Program frees you from friction and from anxious thinking related to status and competition. You become clear on the business life and personal life you want, you start expanding each of the Four Freedoms, and you build a Self-Managing Company.

Eventually, you realize it's easier to plan for 10x progress in terms of time, money, relationship, and purpose than it is to try to push the existing system further by working harder and longer. In **The 10x Ambition Program**, you build on your self-managing foundation and start creating a self-*multiplying* foundation.

Then you're ready to enter a society where everybody's at this stage of thinking and development. And that's **The Free Zone Frontier Program**. Every entrepreneur in the Free Zone is at the top of their game. They've left status concerns behind, they operate with abundance mindsets, and they're ready to collaborate and grow their impact at the very highest levels.

For more information and to register for The Strategic Coach Program, call 416.531.7399 or 1.800.387.3206, or visit us online at strategiccoach.com.

THREE LEVELS OF FREE ZONE

Your own 10x personal and 10x company growth continually transform within an expanding global community of other Self-Multiplying Companies. These entrepreneurs are increasingly bypassing all competition in their industries and markets by creating 10x up to 1,000x collaborations that will grow in IP asset value to US\$15 trillion by 2044.

10X AMBITION

With your increasingly productive and profitable Self-Managing Company, your personal ambition confidently envisions 10x growth in all areas of your business and personal life — certainly within a 10-year period. As this 10x mindset permeates throughout everyone's daily teamwork, the entire organization becomes a Self-Multiplying Company.

SIGNATURE

You identify and establish your Unique Ability as the dynamic center of your business and personal life. This enables you to create a constantly expanding Self-Managing Company in which all team members grow in their creativity, productivity, and collaboration. Your personal income and Free Days increase, and you plan to never retire.

About The Author

Dan Sullivan



Dan Sullivan is the founder and president of The Strategic Coach Inc. and creator of The Strategic Coach® Program, which helps accomplished entrepreneurs reach new heights of success and happiness. He is author of over 50 publications, including *The Great Crossover*, *The 21st Century Agent*, *Creative Destruction*, *How The Best Get Better*, and The Ambition Series of quarterly small books. He is co-author of *Who Not How*, *The Gap And The Gain*, *The Laws of Lifetime Growth*, and *The Advisor Century*.